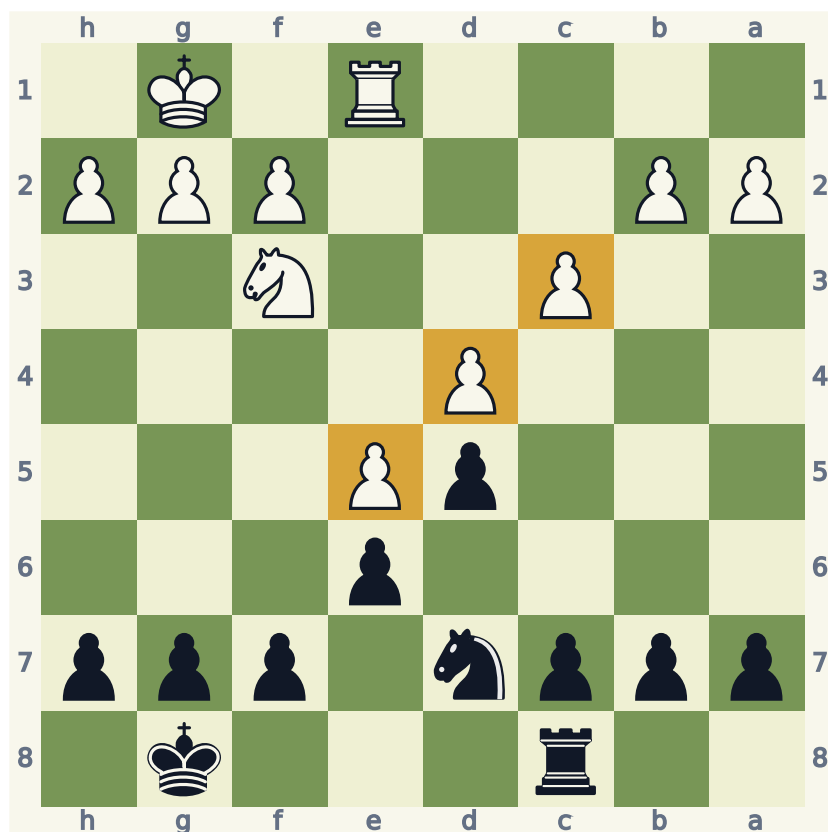


Pawn chains

Attack the support, and understand the direction.

A pawn chain is a diagonal line of mutually connected pawns. Its base is the rear pawn that supports the next link. Attacking the base can undermine the whole chain; attacking the head may open lines more directly. Which method works depends on piece placement and the timing of the break.

MODEL A | BLACK TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- c3 supports d4, which supports e5.
- ...c5 challenges d4, an important supporting link.
- After dxc5, e5 loses its d-pawn support.

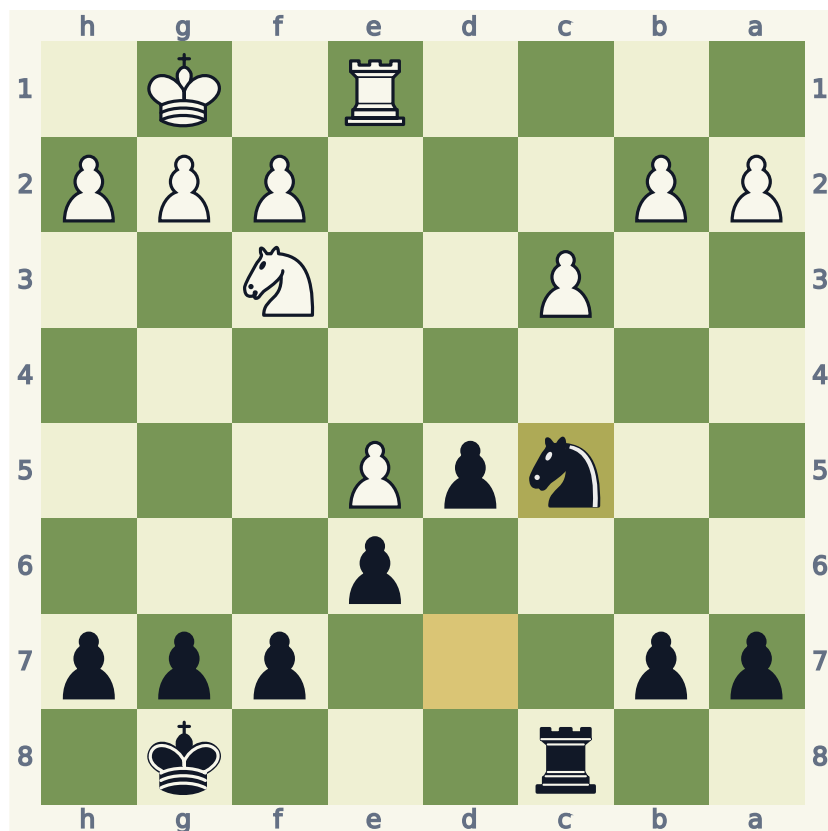
REMEMBER

- Identify the base, links and head.
- Compare attacking support with attacking space.
- Track the piece activity after each break.

Follow the logic

1... c5 2. dxc5 Nxc5

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



...c5

Challenge the central support. White's c3-pawn still supports d4, so Black must calculate captures rather than assume the base collapses.

dxc5

White chooses to release the tension and gives up the pawn that supported e5. This is one possible response, not a forced one.

...Nxc5

The knight gains activity and White's chain is reduced to separate c3 and e5 pawns. Black can now inspect e5 as a target.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

White can support d4 with pieces and keep the chain intact. White may also seek a kingside break because e5 restricts Black there. The direction of a chain suggests a plan but does not force one.

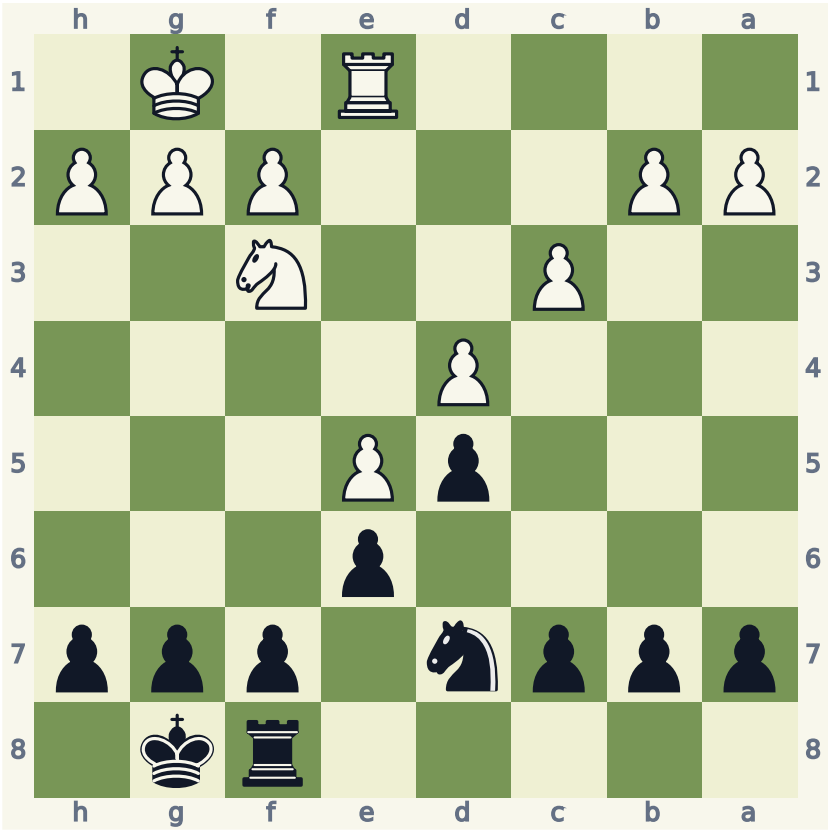
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

The base is not always the easiest target. If it is well defended and the head can be attacked with tempo, striking the head may be more effective. Calculate the lines opened near both kings.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | BLACK TO MOVE



- 1. What part of White's chain does ...f6 attack?
- 2. What remains of the chain after the sample exchange?
- 3. Compare the files affected by ...c5 and ...f6.

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If White had no c3-pawn, what would change about the pressure on d4?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 5rk1/pppn1ppp/4p3/3pP3/3P4/2P2N2/PP3PPP/4R1K1 b - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. ...f6 attacks e5, the head of the chain. This challenges the space-gaining pawn directly rather than its d4 support.
2. After exf6 ...Nxf6, c3 still supports d4, but the advanced e5-pawn has disappeared. Black has gained a useful knight square and reduced White's kingside cramp.
3. ...c5 tends to change the c- and d-files; ...f6 tends to change the e- and f-files and the king shelter. The correct break depends on which pieces can use those lines and whether opening them is safe.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1... f6 2. exf6 Nxf6

Changed feature: d4 would have one fewer pawn defender. Attacking that supporting link could become more effective, especially if a rook or queen also pressures the d-file.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Draw arrows showing pawn support in one of your middlegames. Remove each link mentally and see which pawns lose protection.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 03, 05, 13. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.